

Brittle stars

Look at any part of the seabed and you are likely to find star-shaped creatures with long, slender arms wriggling across the bottom. These are not fish, but invertebrates called brittle stars, and they are relatives of starfish and sea urchins. They are also known as snake stars because of the way they move their arms. *Palaeocoma* was an early kind of brittle star. Wary of predators, *Palaeocoma*, like modern brittle stars, may have hidden in cracks in rocks and corals, coming out only at night to feed.

Palaeocoma

pale-ee-oh-COAM-ah

- **When** Nearly 200 million years ago (Early Jurassic)
- **Fossil location** Europe
- **Habitat** Seafloor
- **Size** 2–4 in (5–10 cm) across
- **Diet** Remains of plants and animals

Palaeocoma had a flat, central disklike body. Extending from it were five long, spiny arms, with which it moved swiftly along the seabed. When disturbed, it could escape quickly, pulling and pushing its body using the muscles in its arms. On the underside of its body was a star-shaped mouth containing five toothed jaws. When feeding, it used the tiny, muscular tube feet underneath its arms to sweep food into its mouth. It had no eyes, but may have been able to sense light through its feet.

